Kissing Lessons

By Joseph Weisberg

The summer after seventh grade, I went to the Busby Berkeley Camp for the Performing Arts in Pinewood, Wisconsin. I went there because I liked to tap-dance. I liked to tap-dance because I had no friends, and when you have no friends, you gravitate naturally towards hobbies and interests which ensure that you will never have any friends.

INTRODUCTION

OK – I'll let you in on a secret, but you can't tell anybody! It's not just girls who feel awkward during their teen-age years – guys have confidence issues too. I know, I know, we don't show it and we don't talk about it and we posture a lot; but being a teen-ager is HARD! Especially when it comes to relating to girls. Let me tell you a story . . a confession really . . . I'll call it . . . Kissing Lessons by Joseph Weisberg

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

The boys at Busby Berkeley were misshapen, bewildered, and talented. Beefo Kellner was tall and blubbery, spent most of his free time in his bunk clipping his toenails, and had a gorgeous tenor voice. Ed Waxman was squat, cross-eyed, and had numerous facial tics, but completely transformed into a sexy Brando-esque actor the moment he stepped onstage. Greg French had red hair gurgling up from his head like lava, never said a word to anyone, and tap-danced with grace and total abandon. The rest of us were hapless variations on these same themes.

The girls at camp were as perfect and put together as the boys were clunky and poorly assembled. Their hair was curled into loose ringlets that tumbled down to their shoulder blades, or blow-dried into lightly feathered Dorothy Hamill bowls. They wore diamond earrings and makeup with blue jeans. All of them came from the suburbs of Chicago-and they seemed more open and sexual than the city girls I was used to. They made no secret of the fact that boys were the center of their universe. And they

flirted constantly. At home, nobody ever flirted with me, and now girls were winking at me from across rooms, giggling while they talked to me, hugging me. I felt like someone who's been raised by a colony of apes, then returns to civilization and suddenly finds himself surrounded by the species he is truly meant to love.

Our show that summer was *How to Succeed in. Business Without Really Trying.* I was cast as J. Pierpont Finch. My big number was a college fight song called "Stand Old Ivy" that J. Pierpont sings with his boss. After the song, I had to go over and kiss Rosemary, the leading lady.

Rosemary was being played by Suzi Tefler, the most beautiful, most popular, and tallest girl at camp. She was a foot taller than me. The idea of kissing her filled me with a constant, jittery dread. I had never kissed a girl, and I didn't really know how.

Everyone my age at camp was in the show, so they were all there, most of them sitting in the audience watching. I sang my song. Then I walked over

4NG Fanatics

to where Suzi Tefler was standing. I turned my back to the audience, closed my eyes, and moved my face towards her, praying that kissing would result.

I felt her breath. Then the electric tingle in front of her lips.

Then Suzi jumped back and at the top of her lungs yelled, "HE BIT ME!"

The audience burst into a loud, punishing laughter. It went on and on, and every time it seemed like it was dying down, it built up again. I wanted to run off the stage but knew it would be a mistake to surrender whatever tiny piece of ground I had left.

Manon Guastafeste was my best friend at camp that summer. Manon was short and hyperactive and had a big, beautiful nose on a Jewish-Mediterranean face. I had a crush on her, but she was going out that summer with Billy Zane. I accepted that I had no chance with her, and we settled into a friendship.

Manon saw how depressed I was after the biting incident. A few days later, as I was shuffling around the no-man's-land between the boys' and

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

girls' cabins, she came up to me and said, "I've solved your problem."

"What do you mean'?" I said.

"I got Nina Steinberg to agree to give you kissing lessons." Nina Steinberg was our friend. And she was cute. Although the idea of kissing lessons wasn't particularly less terrifying than actual kissing, I said, "Okay."

"She'll meet you at Brigadoon tonight at nine o'clock." Every building at camp was named after an old musical. My cabin that summer was South Pacific. The dining hall was Carousel. And the prop shed was Brigadoon.

That night, I rubbed Old Spice deodorant on my underarms and put on my best T-shirt. I opened the barn doors to Brigadoon ten minutes early. The only light, from a street lamp on the basketball court outside, filtered in through one small window near the ceiling. I sat down on an old foot locker and waited. At nine o'clock, Nina slipped in through the bam doors.

4N6 Fanatics

She closed them behind her, then she came and sat down next to me on the trunk.

"Hi," she said.

"Hi."

We sat quietly for a little while.

"So you want to practice kissing?" she said.

"Ummm . . . yeah," I said.

She leaned towards me. I leaned towards her. And in the same instant, our lips were together. Then her lips were pressing and pulling. They were plump. And wet. She went back and forth between my top and bottom lips, taking each one between her lips and squeezing it. After a little while, I started squeezing back.

Then she turned her head sideways and came at me at an angle. She affixed her face to mine and her tongue darted into my mouth. It started moving in and out, this way and that, thick and fast. I lifted my tongue and sort of . . . blocked it. Then I started moving my tongue haphazardly, startled each time it collided with hers. In a place that felt like outer

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

space, I thought, *I'm French-kissing!* Finally, Nina pulled away.

"Okay," she said. "You're a natural."

"Really'?" I said.

"Yeah, you're good at it."

I didn't believe her, but I was glad she said it. "Thanks," I said.

When I got home at the end of the summer, Manon called and told me her family was moving to Chicago, and she was transferring to New City Day School. We were going to be freshmen together. She shrieked and laughed about how great it was going to be. I was ecstatic, too.

****

[The first day of school that fall] Manon came in the door. She scanned the entryway, and then her big, beautiful mouth spread wide when she saw me. She ran at me and threw her arms around me, jumping up and down while we hugged. "Oh my God! I can't believe you're here! I can't believe I'm here! I can't believe it! Oh my God! I can't believe this!"

4NG Fanatics

I looked down into Manon's eyes and said, "You can't hang out with me."

"What do you mean '?" she said.

"Nobody likes me here. If you hang out with me, nobody'll like you, either."

"That's ridiculous!"

"No it isn't."

"We're hanging out all the time. You're my best friend."

"We can't."

"We're going to be together all the time."

I shook my head.

"This is crazy," Manon said. "I don't know anybody else. I love you!"

"No," I said.

Then I pointed to a group of popular girls clustered together across the hall. "They're popular," I said. "Go hang out with them."

"No," she said.

"**Go**."

"No, this is ridiculous."

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

"Go."

Manon looked up at me. She was crying, and she opened her mouth to say something. Then she turned and left.

I waited in the entryway for a little while, then went in to start high school.

****

Junior year, I started to fall into people. First Kevin Dorst, who I was in chorus with, invited me out to dinner one night. Then Bill Fritz, who was on the soccer team with me, started sitting next to me in Latin class.

Once Bill and I were friends, becoming friends with the girls in the clique was as effortless and quick as a sponge soaking up water-one moment you were talking in the hall when they arrived en masse, the next you were sitting between them at Sarah's house and watching *Days of Our Lives*.

Manon had been a member of the clique since I had pointed her to it freshman year. Now we were around each other all the time again. Our friendship

4N6 Fanatics

regrew from the old root. We went back to talking on the phone for hours. We sat next to each other in class and at lunch, we snuck away from parties for conspiratorial discussions of whatever was on her mind. We were constantly huddled together, talking about love, complaining about school, reminiscing about camp. The only thing we never discussed was our separation. There was an unspoken agreement between us that it hadn't happened.

Near the end of junior year, Manon and I were going to a party together. It was my sixteenth birthday, and I was vaguely entertaining the thought that it might be a surprise party for me. It was around eight o'clock, and we were parked on one of the quiet side streets of Lincoln Park. We were talking for a while before going in, in the way we always talked-her going on and on, me absorbing little bits and pieces of what she said.

At one point, when Manon was saying something I wasn't listening to at all, I saw her eyes narrow and focus in on me. "You know, you're a very confident

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

guy," she said.

I sat up straight, and I looked over, and Manon was still talking. I felt something in my toes, and it started climbing, working its way up my body. A feeling of action. Of one fear breaking against another. I started moving across the seat. As I got closer, Manon turned her head and looked at me, all eyes now. And then I was there, and my lips were on hers. Her lips were there. And then they were gone.

She pressed the back of her head against the car window, went a little bug-eyed, and said, "What are you doing?"

I said, "I don't know. I'm sorry."

We sat there for a few minutes, silent.

Then Manon said, "Well, it's not a big deal." Surprisingly, I believed her.

A few minutes later, we walked into the party. Nobody yelled "Surprise!" There were boxes of pizza, Cokes, and Diet Cokes (which the girls called "Dokes"). After we finished eating, the room went black, and everyone started singing "Happy Birthday." Sarah and

4NG Fanatics

Cindy came in carrying a cake. In the dark light of the candles, I saw David's mouth wide open as he hammed up the song. Sarah's eyes locked on me, as if they were searching for something inside me. And Jonah, still eating a piece of pizza, brimming with optimism and joy. I didn't really know why these people had taken me in. But tonight they were singing to me. It didn't feel like love, but it felt like hope.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Joseph Weisberg
Book: Sixteen: Stories About That Sweet and Bitter Birthday
ISBN: 978-1400052707
Publisher: Random House, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): 2004

AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
IL State Finalist